



Partly sunny 61/51 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 78/59 B18

Democracy Dies in Darkness

WEDNESDAY, MARCH 25, 2026 • \$4

Deputy in Fed case undercuts Trump

A prosecutor says the government lacks proof of Powell misconduct

BY SALVADOR RIZZO AND ANDREW ACKERMAN

A top deputy to U.S. Attorney Jeanine Pirro acknowledged in a closed-door hearing this month that the Justice Department did not have evidence of wrongdoing in its criminal investigation of the Federal Reserve over the cost of its building renovations, according to a transcript of the court proceedings.

The prosecutor's admission, which has not been previously reported, undercuts President Donald Trump's claim that "there is criminality" in the \$2.5 billion overhaul of the Fed's headquarters overlooking the National Mall.

Attorneys for the Fed and the U.S. attorney's office in D.C. battled over the legality of two grand jury subpoenas at the center of the investigation during a sealed hearing March 3. A transcript of the proceedings was later unsealed. Both subpoenas were quashed this month by a federal judge, who described them as an illegal effort by the Trump administration to pressure Fed Chair Jerome H. Powell to lower interest rates or resign from the independent central bank.

Pirro, the top federal prosecutor in D.C. and a Trump ally, opened the inquiry after Powell gave brief testimony on the renovation's costs during a congressional hearing last year. The criminal investigation followed years of criticism from Trump over the Fed's handling of monetary policy and his public demands that the Justice Department target his perceived political foes. Prosecutors are weighing whether the

SEE FED ON A2



LEKAN OYEKANMI/AP

Travelers line up Wednesday at a TSA checkpoint at George Bush Intercontinental Airport in Houston. The deal under discussion would fund the department except for the part of ICE charged with arresting and deporting undocumented immigrants.

Senate Republicans pitch deal to end DHS impasse

BY THEODORIC MEYER, ISAAC ARNSDORF AND RILEY BEGGIN

Senate Republicans sent Democrats a new proposal Tuesday to end the partial shutdown of the Department of Homeland Security, which has led to long lines at airport security in recent days and has forced many of the agency's employees to go without pay for more than a month.

The proposal would fund DHS except for the part of Immigration and Customs Enforcement charged with arresting and deporting undocumented immigrants, according to three people familiar with the plan, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss private conversations.

But President Donald Trump did not commit to the potential

But Trump isn't sold, and Democrats still insist on new ICE restrictions

compromise even though several Republican senators pitched him on it Monday evening at the White House.

"I don't want to comment until I see the deal, but as you know, they're negotiating a deal," Trump told reporters Tuesday in the Oval Office. "I guess they're getting fairly close. But I think any deal they make, I'm pretty much not happy with it."

On Sunday, Trump wrote on social media that Republicans should not "make any deal" with Democrats until they support the

voting bill known as the Save America Act, which Senate Democrats unanimously oppose.

Senate Minority Leader Charles E. Schumer (D-New York) said Democrats could not accept any deal that does not include new restrictions that the party demanded after federal immigration agents killed two U.S. citizens in Minnesota. Democrats will send Republicans a counteroffer, Schumer said.

"Every Democrat in my caucus has been consistent all along: We have to rein in ICE and stop the violence," Schumer told reporters. "We need reform."

Republicans, who control the Senate 53-47, would need the support of at least seven senators in the Democratic caucus — which includes two independents — for any deal to overcome a filibuster.

Senate Majority Leader John Thune (R-South Dakota) balked at the idea of agreeing to any of Democrats' demands if Democrats refused to fund ICE.

"If they want to have a conversation about some of the reform ideas that they had put in front of us, then that would be contingent upon actually providing funding for ICE," Thune told reporters.

DHS has been shut down since Feb. 14. Democrats have refused to fund the agency unless Republicans agree to their demands, which include tighter rules governing the use of warrants, barring agents from wearing masks and requiring them to wear body cameras and identification.

The White House has been negotiating with Democrats for more than a month, but the two

SEE DHS ON A8

Trump claims conflict is won

IRAN PUBLICLY DENIES ANY TALKS

President says sides may meet directly 'very soon'

BY KAREN DEYOUNG, SUSANNAH GEORGE AND HEBA FAROUK MAHFOUZ

President Donald Trump said Tuesday that the war in Iran has already been won and regime change achieved as more than three weeks of U.S. and Israeli airstrikes have killed many of Iran's senior leaders and destroyed much of its military capability.

"We're talking to the right leaders, and they want to make a deal so badly," Trump said of nascent U.S.-Iranian talks that were happening "right now," he said in the Oval Office.

Egypt, Pakistan and Turkey have moved to broker a ceasefire amid a new wave of Iranian attacks on Persian Gulf countries and Israel, Iran's continued closure of the Strait of Hormuz and reports that the U.S. is mobilizing additional ground troops to send to the region.

Trump said Tuesday that his son-in-law Jared Kushner, White House envoy Steve Witkoff, Secretary of State Marco Rubio and Vice President JD Vance were all engaged in talks but didn't specify which Iranian leaders were involved.

But, he said, proof that they were talking to the "right people" came when the Iranians "gave us a present, and the present arrived today," suggesting without further

SEE IRAN ON A14

Middle East: Israel and Iran trade strikes as U.S. holds back. A10

High court may permit blocking of migrants

BY JULIAN MARK

The Supreme Court on Tuesday appeared inclined to clear the way for the Trump administration to revive a policy that would allow agents at U.S. borders to block migrants from entering the country to seek asylum.

Such a ruling would leave intact a policy that began during the Obama administration on a small scale and expanded dramatically during President Donald Trump's first term amid efforts to curb the flow of immigration.

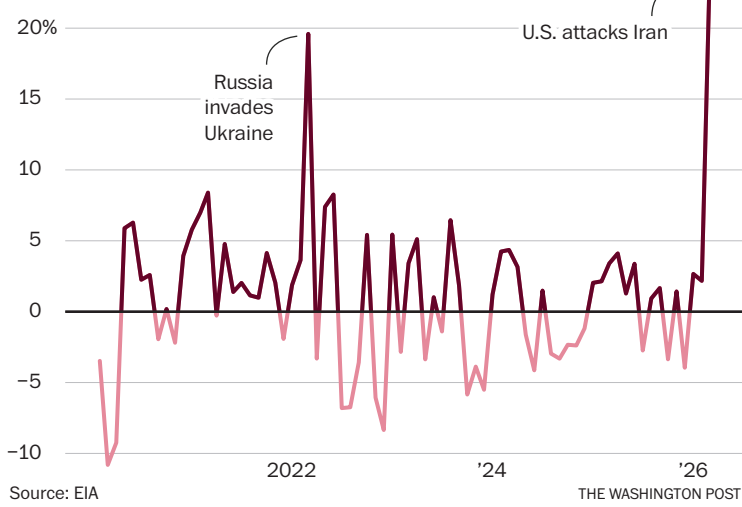
The case centers on how to interpret U.S. immigration laws saying that any noncitizen who "arrives in" the country must be allowed to apply for asylum. Under the policy at issue, called "metering," federal border officials had been intercepting migrants approaching U.S. ports of entry and turning them back before they could reach American soil.

The government says the policy is consistent with the law, but a group of migrants suing the government say that migrants intercepted on the Mexico side of the border must be offered the opportunity to seek asylum.

SEE BORDER ON A4

At a gas station in Colorado, the cost of ongoing war hits home

The spike in average gas prices across the U.S. has surpassed the increase seen when Russia attacked Ukraine in 2022.



Source: EIA

THE WASHINGTON POST

Americans are making changes amid a historic price spike at the pump

BY CASEY PARKS, CHRIS HACKER AND DYLAN MORIARTY

PUEBLO, COLO. — Zac Grant never let his truck run close to empty. Colorado's weather was too unpredictable for that, and lately, the cost of fuel had been, too. In the weeks since the United States had attacked Iran, the price for a gallon had shot up nearly 35 percent in Colorado, a hike that far outpaced the national average, and one the state hadn't seen in at least a quarter century.

Grant, 48, knew he'd pay \$40 more to fill his tank than he used to, but his new Dodge Ram 3500 was nearing a quarter tank, and he had work to do. The temperature was 60 degrees higher than it had been the day before, but he waited to turn on the air conditioning. He called up a free AAA app on his phone to find the

cheapest fuel. A map of Pueblo lit up with little orange boxes. Grant's local station had diesel for \$4.80, and a few others had topped \$5. He let out a low whistle.

"The last time I filled up, it was \$3.07," he said. "It will be a sting."

War always has its casualties, Grant knew, and the amount he would pay that day was but one data point in a swirl of effects that was reshaping the global economy by the hour. With oil tankers struggling to navigate the narrow Strait of Hormuz, the price of a barrel of oil had climbed to more than \$100. The war-triggered spike was the largest gas price increase in 30 years, according to a Washington Post analysis of data from the U.S. Energy Information Administration. Here in Pueblo, where the price of gas had risen an entire dollar since the start of the war, that meant people were making

SEE GAS PRICES ON A10

Wildfires rip through unusual parts of U.S., raising fears of a brutal season

BY BRIANNA SACKS AND BEN NOLL

By late March, Nebraska was already in the throes of a historic wildfire event that had burned more than a half-million acres. In South Dakota and Wyoming, strong, dry winds are flaring up big blazes. Dozens of residents in two Colorado counties had to evacuate over the weekend as record hot temperatures and ex-

tremely low humidity fueled the rapid spread of fires in the parched brush. And until last week, it was still technically winter.

Wildfires are ripping across the Great Plains, and other flare-ups are popping up in Arizona and Colorado remarkably early in the season. Firefighters and experts are watching these giant red splotches of burning forest and grasslands with alarm, warn-

ing that the timing, ingredients fueling their startling growth, and what they signal about the fire season ahead is a recipe for concern — perhaps signaling an expanding frontier for fire risk in broader patches of the western half of the United States.

"To sum it up," Pete Curran, a staff meteorologist for Watch Duty, a nonprofit that tracks wildfires live and sends updates to users in real time, and former

captain at the Orange County Fire Authority, put it bluntly: "We are scared s---less."

"To have any fire that goes hundreds of thousands of acres in a day anywhere is very unusual at any time of the year, let alone in mid-March," he added about the blazes in Nebraska. "It got everyone's attention."

Many fire-prone parts of the country did not get a real, substantial winter, one that typically

leaves mountains and soil with a solid snowpack to help cushion the transition into unrelenting summer heat. Combine that with the kind of dry cold fronts that brought powerful fire-igniting winds in late February in the Oklahoma Panhandle and southern Kansas; an unprecedented heat dome parked over a slew of states from California to the Great Plains that brought the

SEE FIRES ON A2

IN THE NEWS

Deadly LaGuardia crash A plane's cockpit voice recorder captured how air traffic control failed to recognize that it was given access to the same runway as a vehicle. A6

Immigration crackdown Minnesota officials sued the Trump administration, alleging evidence was withheld in three shootings. A3

THE NATION The nascent MAHA movement got one of its biggest wins last spring: Casey Means was picked to be surgeon general. More than 10 months later, she has yet to assume the position. A4

The president voted by mail in a Florida special election for the state legislature, a method he has called "cheating." A3
Energy executive Alan Armstrong will fill the Senate seat vacated by the new DHS chief. A7

THE ECONOMY A Democratic senator launched a probe into the two largest for-profit child care providers amid soaring prices. A18
These frugal habits may be too extreme even when times are hard, plus a few other penny-pinching favorites from readers. A18

STYLE A three-day Polymar-ket pop-up event drew young professionals, journalists — and the simply curious. B1

SPORTS The NCAA men's Sweet 16 comes to D.C. on Friday, bringing with it a coaching legend facing top-seeded Duke. B7

THE REGION Two men have been arrested and charged in the D.C. shooting of an undercover U.S. Park Police officer. B13

FOOD A cake is always a cause for celebration — unless something goes awry. If it turns out dense or dry, here's what to check.

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